

At the beginning of my coursework, I understood advocacy as helping clients find resources or speaking up for them when they needed support. As I have progressed through the counseling program, I have learned that advocacy is much more than that. I now understand that counselors can advocate for clients in many different ways, including helping them overcome barriers, educating others, and making sure their voices are heard. I have also learned that advocacy starts with understanding each client's individual background, culture, and experiences. This has helped me see how important it is to be aware of the challenges that different populations may face when trying to access mental health services.

One way I have grown in this area is through my involvement with Comunidad de Consejeros Bilingües (CCB) and the different workshops and educational opportunities I have participated in. For example, attending the Immigration: Protecting Your Clients workshop helped me better understand the importance of being knowledgeable about immigration-related concerns and how they may affect clients and families. I have also learned about the importance of using inclusive and affirming language when working with diverse populations. These experiences have helped me recognize that advocacy can happen in the counseling room through something as simple as respecting a client's language, culture, identity, and individual needs.

As a bilingual counselor in training, I especially want to use my language skills to help reduce barriers and make mental health services more accessible to Spanish-speaking clients. Overall, I feel that I have grown in my understanding of advocacy since I first began my coursework. I no longer see advocacy as something separate from counseling, but rather as an important part of being an effective counselor.